

ing to convince those who live very close to the poverty line or under it that a mobile device with a data plan can be very beneficial to them.

If China was to go on strike, this goal would be dropped like a hot potato, at least temporarily, because it would be obvious that the next billion simply would not be able to afford it. Prices of everything else in their lives would go up, and thus, things that are considered a luxury, or not essential to immediate survival would be forgotten. People would hang on to dumb phones and delay upgrades to smartphones. A new TV, or PC/laptop, etc, would all be put on the backburner.

APPREHENSION

When prices jump, it's not just the poor who sit up and take notice, it's the middle class who are affected as well. Given the sheer size of India's middle class, this would be a huge blow to companies catering to them. Thankfully, the COVID-19 situation has shown that sales have not stopped, and in fact because of lockdowns delaying plans to buy a phone, the release of the lockdowns actually resulted in an almost festival level of shopping in tech. That said, this might only be because prices didn't skyrocket, and cabin fever resulted in many wanting to feel a return to normalcy. How would buyers react to a sudden jump in prices of everything, not just technology, is anyone's guess.

This apprehensiveness caused by a huge mismatch in the supply demand ratio might also be a good thing, and allow us with time to try and recover from the initial shock.

SURFACE TENSION

So many of us are so clumsy with our tech, especially phones. Who hasn't dropped a phone and watched in horror as it bounces about like no electronic device ever should? Then, as you rush to pick it up and caress it the way we would a child that fell flat on its face, we notice the cracked screen, and after a moment of agony that can evoke tears and sobbing, we start to do mental calculations about what this is going to cost us.

In a world where tech is far more expensive, many of us will be heading to service centres and repair shops to try and eke out as much life as we can from our devices. Of course, the cost of repairing will jump too, because spare parts also mostly come from China. Thankfully there will be enough stock to last a few months at least, so we're not going to run out immediately.

Those who are technically inclined will be able to DIY their own repairs, and it might be a shot in the arm that the maker revolution needs to get restarted globally. 3D printing and additive manufacturing showed a lot of promise when they were new ideas,

brands to locals that enabled them to build the expertise in manufacturing at all levels. More skilled labour available results in lower wages, because supply outstrips demand.

No country is as insular now as China was back then, which means by default no one can follow in their footsteps. This is both good and bad for certain aspects. While it will certainly result in higher costs for everything, and there will be fewer cheap knockoffs that can service the extreme budget segment, it will also result in better quality devices, and increase the overall reliability of technology as a whole.

Based on what I know, China is seriously considering restricting rare earth exports to the U.S. China may also take other countermeasures in the future

—Hu Xijin, Global Times Editor in Chief

<https://digit.in/remilit>

and then they became something that was super niche in the grand scheme of things. However, if it was possible for you to go to a local additive manufacturer and 'print' yourself a new case for your phone, you might not care that e-tailers don't seem to stock the plethora of options that they used to. Especially if the prices for both options were almost the same.

Another aspect that you might actually benefit from is that the resale value of your used and older phones would suddenly jump up. Depending on how much in demand the parts of your phone were, you could end up actually making a profit on a three year old phone!

QUESTIONABLE ETHICS

What we would not be able to do in the 2020s is what China did in the 2000s and 2010s, which is thumb their nose at intellectual property and just copy, copy, copy. It was all of the copying and selling of Chinese

Because no agency working in China is actually independent, especially not the Central Bank, the country is able to manipulate things to suit themselves like no other country ever could. No other country that could pitch in to replace China could be run the way China is. This means that growth would be slower, or it might result in some countries heading down the same path as China – a bad thing for freedom of their citizens, obviously.

INTERLOPER

In 2018, a team at Macquarie Research, an Australian investment bank group, did the same thought experiment as us and considered a world without China – something we only discovered after we came up with the idea independently of course. Because they're economists, they did it purely as a thought experiment in the economics field as market research, and what they found was